

Ethics and Careers in Security



BIG IDEA Security skills are powerful, and the line between a defender and a lawbreaker is permission. Know the law, the ethics and the pathways, and if you find a flaw, there is a right way to report it.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Say: “A locksmith who opens your door because you locked yourself out, and a person who opens it because they felt like it, use the same skills. What separates them is permission. That is the entire ethical line. Professionals look for weaknesses only with written permission and inside a defined scope. Without permission, even a curious ‘I was just checking’ attempt can be illegal, and teens have faced real consequences. Today: the law in plain terms, what to do if you accidentally find a flaw, and a next step toward a career. We will learn to be the person who gets hired.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Green Light / Red Light*

- 1 (1 min) The law in plain terms.** In the US, the CFAA makes it a crime to access a computer without authorization or beyond the access you were given. Minors can be charged, and “I did no damage” or “I was only curious” is no safe defense. Permission is the line. General information, not legal advice.
- 2 (4 min) Sort the Scenario Cards** in pairs into GREEN (permission and scope clear), YELLOW (ask first) or RED (stop), and name the letter of P-S-H-T that decided it. Examples: an official beginner practice event (green); “just guess a few” of an ex’s password (red); your school portal shows another student’s data (yellow: stop, share nothing, tell an adult); pay for “easy tasks” that mean getting into accounts (red: recruitment).
- 3 (2 min) The “I found a flaw” routine. Stop.** Keep no one’s data. Do not share it or boast. **Tell** the owner privately, or a trusted adult who can help. **Wait** for a reply. That is responsible disclosure.
- 4 (1 min) Careers and free pathways.** Hand out the Career Postcards and pathways handout; name two programs and let students read the rest after class. Each pair writes one free first step on W9 (for example, ask the counselor about the CTE pathway).

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Why does ‘I did no damage’ not make access okay?”
- 2** “How is a practice event different from hacking a real company? Why does scope matter?”
- 3** “Someone offers money for ‘easy’ tasks involving other people’s accounts. How do you recognize recruitment?”

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R9 Permission Test card per student, ten Scenario Cards, Career Postcards and pathways handout; Workbook W9; board zones GREEN, YELLOW, RED. No accounts are created in class.

- ☐ Post the Permission Test: Permission (written), Scope, Harm, Tell.
- ☐ Guardrail: law, ethics and pathways only, never attack techniques. Redirect “how do I hack X.”
- ☐ One Scenario deck per pair (or three cards each).

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause at ‘do I have permission?’ Check the scope and the harm. Tell the owner or a trusted adult if you find something. The skills are the same for defenders and attackers; the choices make you one or the other. Add: ‘My permission rule is _____, and my next step toward a security path is _____.’”

Hand signal: Hackles up? A “job” or “favor” that skips permission is a trigger (hand brushed up the neck, optional). Post it: “The skill is the same. Permission is the difference.”

EXIT TICKET “A friend says ‘it is only a prank, just try their password.’ Write your response using one part of the Permission Test.”

FUN BOOST Permission Showdown. Pairs defend one Yellow card to another pair using one letter of P-S-H-T.

LEVEL-UP Disclosure Message. Write the plain message to a fictional organization reporting a flaw. Never practice on anyone else’s accounts.

DIFFERENTIATE The Permission Test with icons, simpler scenarios, a word bank (authorization, scope, disclosure).

FAMILY CARD Ask: “What is the Permission Test? What security job sounds interesting?” Agree: practice only on systems built for it, never anyone else’s accounts or devices.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.”
- “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.”
- “I can’t keep this secret. I need to bring in people who can help, and I will tell you who.”
- **Do not say:** “Why did you...?” or “How could you...?”
- “I won’t tell anyone.”
- “You should have told someone sooner.”

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.